

intellectual tradition in Europe that locates knowledge in language and that argues for the 'revelation' of truth by means of linguistic analysis. According to this intellectual tradition, there is an ontological link between letters and words on the one hand, and the basic components of reality on the other. The influence of kabbalistic spirituality in the emergence and continuity of such an interpretation cannot be overemphasized.

Linguistic Ontologies in Christian Kabbalah

All representatives of early modern esotericism were influenced by the Jewish kabbalah to a greater or lesser degree. This influence became more evident, the more Hebrew texts were available in Latin translation. In the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries partial translations of the Zohar, the works of Gikatilla, and other 'classical' texts were produced, so that Christian authors could make full use of them. Many Christian authors regarded Hebrew as a sacred language that had been spoken in the Garden of Eden, but as we have seen in chapter two, this interest in Jewish sources was by no means a neutral process of exchange or dialogue. More often it was marked by a polemic tone with attempts to prove the 'truth' of Christianity with the aid of Jewish sources.

This polemic notwithstanding, what we witness here is a 'shared passion' of Jewish and Christian authors for the Platonic alternative to nominalist positions. That is why the kabbalistic tradition attracted so many Christians who were interested in the ultimate ontological structures of the cosmos. The rediscovery of the Platonic tradition in the fifteenth century went hand in hand with the emergence of kabbalistic approaches to language in Christian milieus. Even the formation of an academic discipline called 'philology' was informed by the search of absolute sources of wisdom. But before I deal with humanistic philology in more detail, let us have a look at Giovanni Pico della Mirandola and Johannes Reuchlin, two of the most influential Christian kabbalists.

Despite a nominalist tendency in a number of his *conclusiones*, Giovanni Pico della Mirandola participated in the ontologization of language in his reception and interpretation of kabbalah. For instance, the nominalist thesis, "No definition is adequate to the thing defined," is preceded by an ultimately Platonic thesis, saying that "Quiddities

[*quiditates*, i.e. ‘whatnesses’] possess their formal existence from eternity from themselves, not from something outside themselves.”⁴² Stephen A. Farmer notes that the “views expressed here illustrate the inadequacy of traditional labels such as ‘realist’ or ‘nominalist’ when applied to premodern philosophers and their hierarchical systems. Both elements can commonly be found at different levels of those systems.”⁴³

Although we should indeed look very closely at what the differences between realist and nominalist approaches in those authors are, and even if we cannot generalize these arguments, the basic challenge and dilemma of nominalist argumentation remain. What we see in Pico is a very creative, though not really consistent, attempt to bridge the gap between those conflicting positions. Pico is wrestling with the dilemmas and paradoxes of perfect knowledge and does not arrive at a less paradoxical argumentation. Thesis 3>6 (ed./trans. Farmer), for instance, alludes to the ‘wisdom beyond demonstration’ as discussed in the previous chapter, stating: “Just as knowledge through demonstration [*cognitio per demonstrationem*], due to the general state that we experience here, is the most perfect knowledge [*perfectissima cognitio*] had by man, so simply speaking among all knowledge it is the most imperfect.” That human understanding must transgress syllogistic demonstration in order to know something in the realm of metaphysics and the divine, is expressed in thesis 3>9 (ed./trans. Farmer): “True metaphysics, treated metaphysically, deals with whatever is a true form as its first subject, and with whatever exists formally as its secondary object, in its methods disregarding demonstration [*in modo procedendi demonstrationem negligens*].”

For Pico, kabbalah provides a means to link rational demonstration with a perfect knowledge of the divine. Language and the combination of letters and numbers are the most important tools in his approach. In the dialectic of concealment and disclosure the sefirotic world serves as the major metaphor for understanding the process of creation and revelation. Thesis 11>35 (ed./trans. Farmer) states:

⁴² Theses 3.6 and 3.5 in Farmer’s edition. For nominalist tendencies, see also theses 7.41, 13.1, 2>2–3, 2>46, 3>2–7 ed. Farmer.

⁴³ Farmer, *Syncretism in the West*, 400 note.

If God is known in himself as infinite, as one, and as existing through himself, we recognize that nothing proceeds from him, but know his separation from things, and his total closure of himself in himself, and his extreme, profound, and solitary retraction in the remotest recess of his divinity; and we recognize him as he conceals himself inwardly in the abyss of his darkness, in no way revealing himself in the dilation and profusion of his goodness and fontal splendor.

Falling back on the kabbalistic concept of *Ein-Sof* as God's transcendent nature enables Pico to study the revelatory form of the divine without intermingling with the divinity itself. Although the ultimate truth of the divine remains unknown, it is through the sefirot that the human being can experience and grasp the perfect source of all knowledge. Consequently, Pico makes use of the traditional metaphor of 'garments' to explain this paradox: "From the preceding conclusion we can know why the Cabalists say that God dressed himself in ten garments [*decem uestimentis*] when he created the world" (11>36, ed./trans. Farmer). The 'garments' are the necessary form of transmitting ultimate metaphysical truth into the revealed world. "Nothing spiritual, descending below, operates without a garment" (thesis 38>35, ed./trans. Farmer). Like Jewish kabbalists, Pico, too, describes the sefirot as garments of divine speech. The written Torah is the direct result of such a process, as Pico explains in thesis 11>70 (ed./trans. Farmer). "Through the method of reading without points [vowel signs] in the Law, we are shown both the method of writing divine things and the unial containment of divine things through an unlimited compass." Consequently, the process of creation is an act of naming and writing, which leads Pico—again in congruence with the *Sefer Yetzirah* and Jewish kabbalistic thought—to make the link between language, magic, and creation. "Voices and words have efficacy in a magical work, because in that work in which nature first exercises magic, the voice is God's"; "Every voice has power in magic insofar as it is shaped by the voice of God" (theses 9>19–20, ed./trans. Farmer). And finally: "Out of the principles of the more secret philosophy it is necessary to acknowledge that characters and figures are more powerful in a magical work than any material quality" (9>24 ed./trans. Farmer).

This brings us to Johannes Reuchlin (1455–1522), indisputably the most important representative of Christian kabbalah at the beginning of the sixteenth century. Scholars such as Joseph Blau und Gershom Scholem celebrated him as the first researcher of kabbalah in history,

who did more for Jewish literature than many a rabbi.⁴⁴ Both his major works, “The Wonder-Working Word” (*De verbo mirifico*, 1494) and especially “The Art of the Kabbalah” (*De arte cabalistica*, 1517), have been held in high regard by Christian kabbalists. With his Hebrew grammar, published in 1506, he laid the basis of research into the Hebrew language and biblical studies.⁴⁵ Writing also under the pseudonym Capnion, Reuchlin was an ardent follower of Pico della Mirandola and took up several of the Italian’s kabbalistic theses in order to elaborate them into a general theory.⁴⁶ In *De verbo mirifico* it was primarily the kabbalistic derivation of the name of Jesus, which Reuchlin used and which provided the book with its title. By inserting a *Shin* into the middle of the Tetragrammaton YHWH, one obtains YHShWH, which is no one else but “YeHoShUH,” that is “Jesus.”⁴⁷ Reuchlin further explains that the letter *Shin* occurs in such significant words as *shemen* (“oil”) and *mashiach* (“anointed,” “Messiah”), and every individual can experience the supreme knowledge of the sciences and ultimately the deification of human nature once he has been anointed by Jesus Christ. Both this interpretation and his emphasis of the wonder-working word demonstrate how strongly Reuchlin wished to integrate magical traditions into Christianity.⁴⁸

De arte cabalistica, then, is also the first complete account of a kabbalistic system written by a non-Jew. Like *De verbo mirifico*, Reuchlin’s second major work is composed in the form of a discussion between

⁴⁴ On Reuchlin and the kabbalah see Gröninger, “Reuchlin und die Kabbala”; Schmidt-Biggemann, “Johannes Reuchlin und die Anfänge der christlichen Kabbala”; Herzig & Schoeps (eds.), *Reuchlin und die Juden*. See also the introductions to the editions of Busi & Campanini, *Johannes Reuchlin: L’arte cabalistica*, VII–LXX; Goodman & Goodman, *Johann Reuchlin: De Arte Cabalistica*, 7–32 (by G. Lloyd Jones).

⁴⁵ Reuchlin’s *Rudimenta linguae hebraicae* was one of the first Hebrew grammars for Christians. It was based on the *Michlol* by David Kimchi. On the history of Hebrew grammar going back to the tenth century, see Kotjatko, “Geschichte der hebräischen Grammatik.”

⁴⁶ See Beierwaltes, “Reuchlin und Pico della Mirandola.”

⁴⁷ Pico did not take this step. However, Nicholas of Cusa (1401–1464) offered a precedent for Reuchlin in his sermon *Dies sanctificatus* (1445); see Schmidt-Biggemann (ed.), *Christliche Kabbalah*, 19. The unutterable Jewish Tetragrammaton becomes pronounceable for Reuchlin as a Pentagram (i.e., a word with five letters); this utterability is once again interpreted as a symbol of the incarnation of the divine in Jesus.

⁴⁸ See Zika, *Exorcising Our Demons*, 21–67. The magical aspect of his doctrines and their clear traces of Jewish and Muslim tradition—for example the *Picatrix* or the magic of “Abramelin of Worms”—have been more fully discussed than heretofore in recent research; see Roling, “Complete Nature of Christ.”

three persons: Marranus, a circumcised and baptized Muslim, Simon⁴⁹ as a Jewish kabbalist, and Philolaus, a Christian and Pythagorean. In the idiom of his age, Reuchlin describes the kabbalah as a precursor of Pythagoreanism, but he names only Plato and Aristotle among the other *prisci theologi*. The kabbalah is an original form of philosophical wisdom-teaching, which must now be made accessible once again. For this reason, the magical elements of the doctrine, which still loomed large in *De verbo mirifico*, play a relatively minor role twenty years later. This is not to say that Reuchlin is no longer interested in the practical aspect of the kabbalah, but his chief concern is now to ‘wing’ the soul upwards to God, rather than ‘drawing down’ the divine.

In *De arte cabalistica*, Reuchlin also engages the various forms of knowledge and the wisdom that is hidden in language. In a line of argument that we have come across so often, the supreme knowledge cannot be attained by intellectual reasoning only.

This goes beyond the intellectual faculties of all of us: we are unable by rational methods to entertain things that are by definition contradictory. We are used to things that are by their very nature obvious. Rationality falls far short of the infinite power we have been talking about, it cannot simultaneously connect these contradictories that are separated by infinity. (A German philosopher-archbishop handed down this dictum some fifty-two years ago.)⁵⁰

Perfect knowledge is achieved by non-rational experience and ultimately by receiving revelations from the angelic sphere. “Thus arises the Kabbalist’s intimate friendship with the angels, through which he comes to know, in the proper manner, something of the divine names and does wonderful things (commonly known as miracles).”⁵¹ It is an intuitive, experiential approach to language and names that characterizes kabbalah in Reuchlin’s presentation. The ultimate goal of the process of achieving knowledge is *deificatio*.

This is what used to be called “deification,” when exterior sense passes from the immediate object to the inner sense, and that passes to the imagination, imagination to thought, thought to reason, reason to

⁴⁹ The name of the Jewish authority on kabbalah obviously refers to Simon bar-Yochai, the alleged second-century author of the *Sefer ha-Zohar*.

⁵⁰ Reuchlin, *De arte cabalistica*, ed./trans. Goodman & Goodman, 123. The “German philosopher-archbishop” is Nicholas of Cusa.

⁵¹ *Ibid.*

understanding, understanding to reflection, and reflection to the light which enlightens man and clasps to itself that enlightenment.⁵²

In this process of illumination the human being has to climb intellectually along ten stages to reach the ultimate goal. For Reuchlin, the kabbalistic sefirot represent those ten stages of perfecting knowledge, which is apparent when we consider the terms he uses to describe the sefirot:

So, my friends, there you have ten sephiroth by which man apprehends things: the object, the *diaphane*, outer sense, inner sense, *phantasia*, lower judgment, higher judgment, reason, and intellect. These are not the “what” so much as the “how” of acting. The highest thing in man—mind—is something else again. Just as God wears the Crown in the kingdom of the world, so is the mind of man chief among the ten Sephiroth, and so it is rightly called “The Crown,” [...].⁵³

The important constellation for the contemplative knowledge of the divine is the highest triad of *ratio*, *intellectus*, and *mens*. While *ratio* and *intellectus* still belong to the higher human faculties, *mens* attaches itself already to divine knowledge. According to Reuchlin, the *intellectus* functions as a connecting faculty between *ratio* and *mens*; *intellectus* moves beyond rationality, even though it is not equivalent to perfect, divine knowledge.

This description is reminiscent of the conception of kabbalah found in Abulafia and (early) Gikatilla, according to which with the aid of the intellect the human being scales the ladder of knowledge. The path to the messiah leads through the understanding of the letters in the name of the messiah, which contains the hidden name of God: “According to the Kabbalists, the Messiah has only one name, the unpronounceable YHWH. This will fulfill and perfect his ordinary name.”⁵⁴ With

⁵² “Haecilla est quae paulo ante a nobis vocabatur deificatio, cum ab obiecto praesente per medium suum exterior sensus transit in sensionem interiorum, et illa in imaginationem, et imaginatio in existimationem, et existimatio in rationem, et ratio in intellectum, et intellectus in mentem, et mens in lucem, quae illuminat hominem, et illud natum in se corripit” (*ibid.*, 46; trans. p. 47).

⁵³ “Habetis itaque viri solertissimi decem numerationes quibus homini contingit rerum apprehensio, quae sunt obiectum, diaphanon, sensus exterior, sensus interior, phantasia, iudicium inferius, iudicium superius, ratio et intellectus. Et haec omnia non tam sunt quid, quem quo. Suprema vero mens in homine aliud quid est. Quapropter sicut deus in mundo, ita mens in homine inter decem Sephiroth regni gerit diadema, et recte cognoscitur” (*ibid.*, 50; trans. p. 51).

⁵⁴ *Ibid.*, 113. On the letter *Shin* as important addition to the Tetragrammaton, see also *ibid.*, 115.

such a conclusion, Reuchlin presents a messianic—or, rather, Christological—version of the ontologization of language in kabbalah.

The mystification of language by Christian kabbalists on the basis of Jewish kabbalistic spirituality exerted an enormous influence on religious and philosophical discourses in the seventeenth century. Scholars such as Francis Mercury van Helmont (1614–1698) and Christian Knorr von Rosenroth (1631–1689) adopted and elaborated kabbalistic speculations in a climate of high political and religious tension. For the subsequent reception of kabbalistic thought, it is particularly Knorr von Rosenroth's partial Latin translation of key sources of Jewish kabbalah, printed under the title *Kabbala Denudata* ("Kabbalah Unveiled") at Sulzbach in 1677, that has to be mentioned here.⁵⁵ This encyclopaedic work contained portions of the *Sefer ha-Zohar*, extracts from Gikatilla's work, and the treatise *De anima* ("On the Soul") by Moses Cordovero, along with other kabbalistic texts.⁵⁶ One can justifiably say that not until *Kabbala Denudata* was published did Christian Europe gain access to the Jewish kabbalah, if only in a selection indebted to the Christian interests of the age. Right up to the twentieth century, esotericists unversed in Hebrew would essentially draw their knowledge of kabbalah from this work.

In his conception of the ontological status of letters and words, Knorr made use of Gikatilla's kabbalistic speculation in particular. It was this influential Jewish kabbalist who had developed an idea of the Torah as textile of names that organically group around the Tetragrammaton like 'twigs around a tree-trunk.'

The Torah can be read as a symbolic texture of metonymically arranged names; in a hierarchical structure all names come together in the one name of the four letters. Thus, the Torah is an encrypted theosophical text about the hidden divine nature and its presence and impact in the world. But not only Torah as building plan of the world, but ultimately all forms of revelation—hence also the world and language—are woven from the divine name.⁵⁷

It is this speculation of Gikatilla's that Knorr von Rosenroth picks up in his own writings. What is more, he combines this ontology of words

⁵⁵ On the book, its context and reception history see the contributions in Kilcher (ed.), *Kabbala Denudata*.

⁵⁶ On the structure and a synopsis of *Kabbala denudata* see Kilcher, "Synopsis."

⁵⁷ Kilcher, *Sprachtheorie der Kabbalah*, 74. See also Morlok, "Text als Textur," 163–165.